

SLR

PHOTOGRAPHY GUIDE



June 2019

Photoshop Alternatives

Word Of Mouth Advertising

<https://www.slrphotographyguide.com>

2019

JUNE EDITION

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<https://www.slrphotographyguide.com>



Cover photo by Cathy Callaghan, AU
ISO 800, f/2.8, 1/160 second

Night Sky Photography Course

Who wants to join me in exploring the night sky this star season?

Excited to have our Night Sky Photography Course now live over at <https://www.slrphotographyguide.com/nightsky-course/>

In this course you'll learn how to photograph Milky Way landscapes as well as Deep Sky objects like Nebulas, Galaxies, Star Clusters and Planets (no telescope).

This course includes Assignment Sheets that you can take with you out in the field.

All you need is a basic DSLR or mirrorless camera + a wide angle lens + a lens that can reach 100 or 200mm focal length.

Highlights

Alternatives To Photoshop	8 - 13
Photography Lessons	18 - 23
Marketing Tips For Photographers	24 - 29
Word Of Mouth Advertising	30 - 33
Monthly Challenge	34 - 37
Embrace Failure	38 - 40





Student image by Julia Simon, US
ISO 280, f/2.8, 1/1000 second



Student image by Shiannon Corcoran, AU
ISO 100, f/5.6, 1/125 second



Student image by Lorraine Williams, AU
ISO 400, f/5.6, 1/125 second

Alternatives To Photoshop

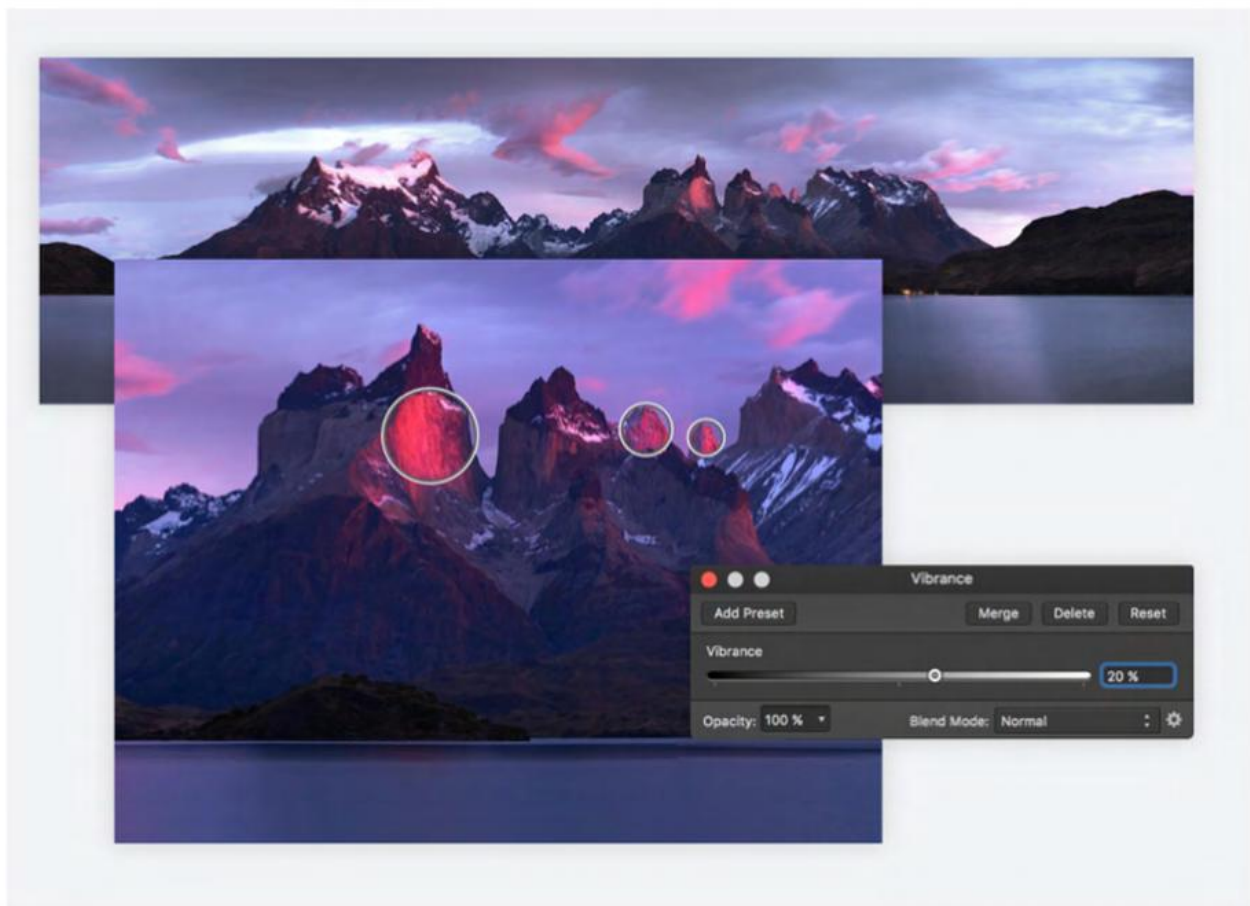
Adobe Photoshop is hands down the go-to editor for photographers all around the world. It is no doubt the best editor available today. However not everyone wants to be tied into a monthly fee to edit images.

In this article we are going to discuss some of the best alternatives to Photoshop that come with either a free or a once off fee.



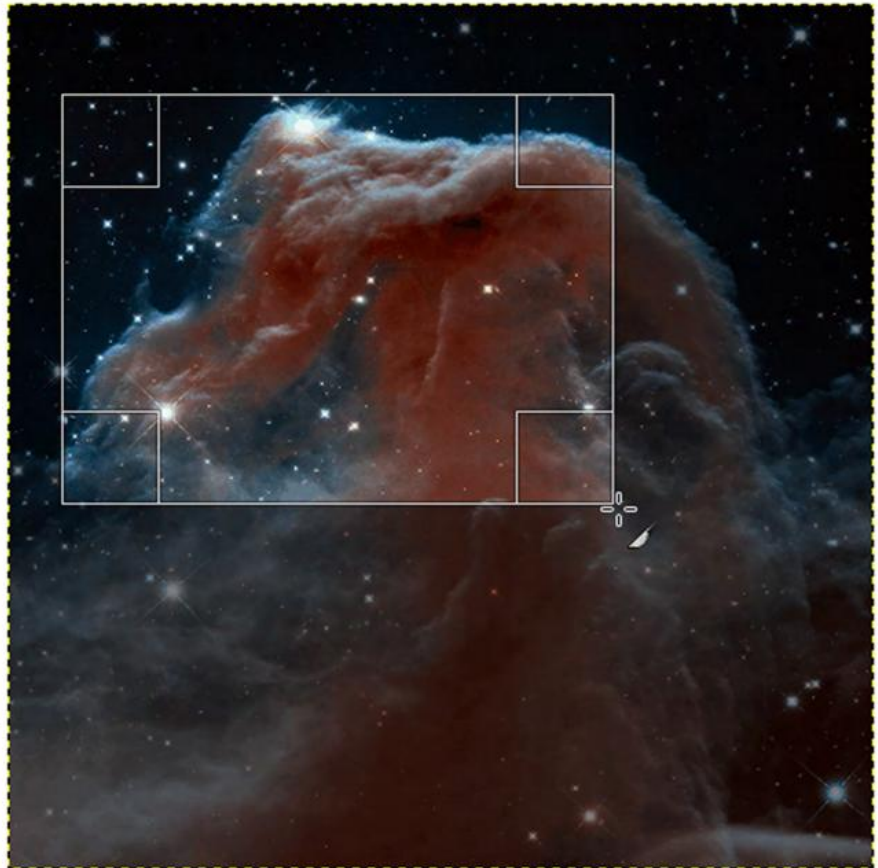
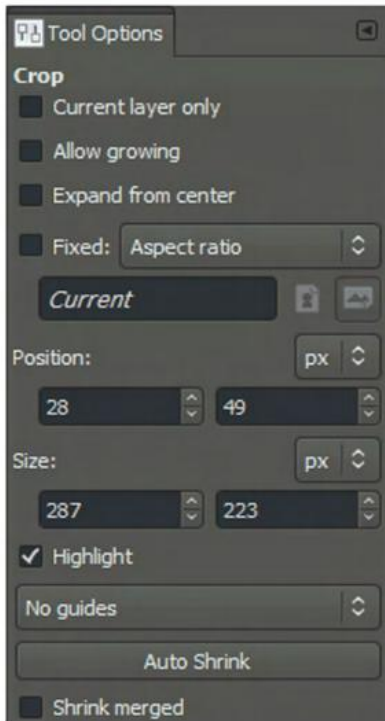
1. Affinity Photo - <https://affinity.serif.com/en-gb/photo/>

Affinity Photo is available for OSX , Windows and Ipad. It has a huge toolset, designed for hobbyist and professional photographers alike. Like Photoshop, you correct and enhance images. You can use Levels, Curves, Blacks and Whites, White Balance, HSL, Shadows and Highlights. It is also non-destructive. Meaning you can return to the original whenever you wish. HDR merging, Panorama Stitching, focus stacking and batch processing are all available with this software. The only downside is that it is a little slower than Photoshop. But for a once off \$80 USD it's definitely Adobe's biggest competitor.



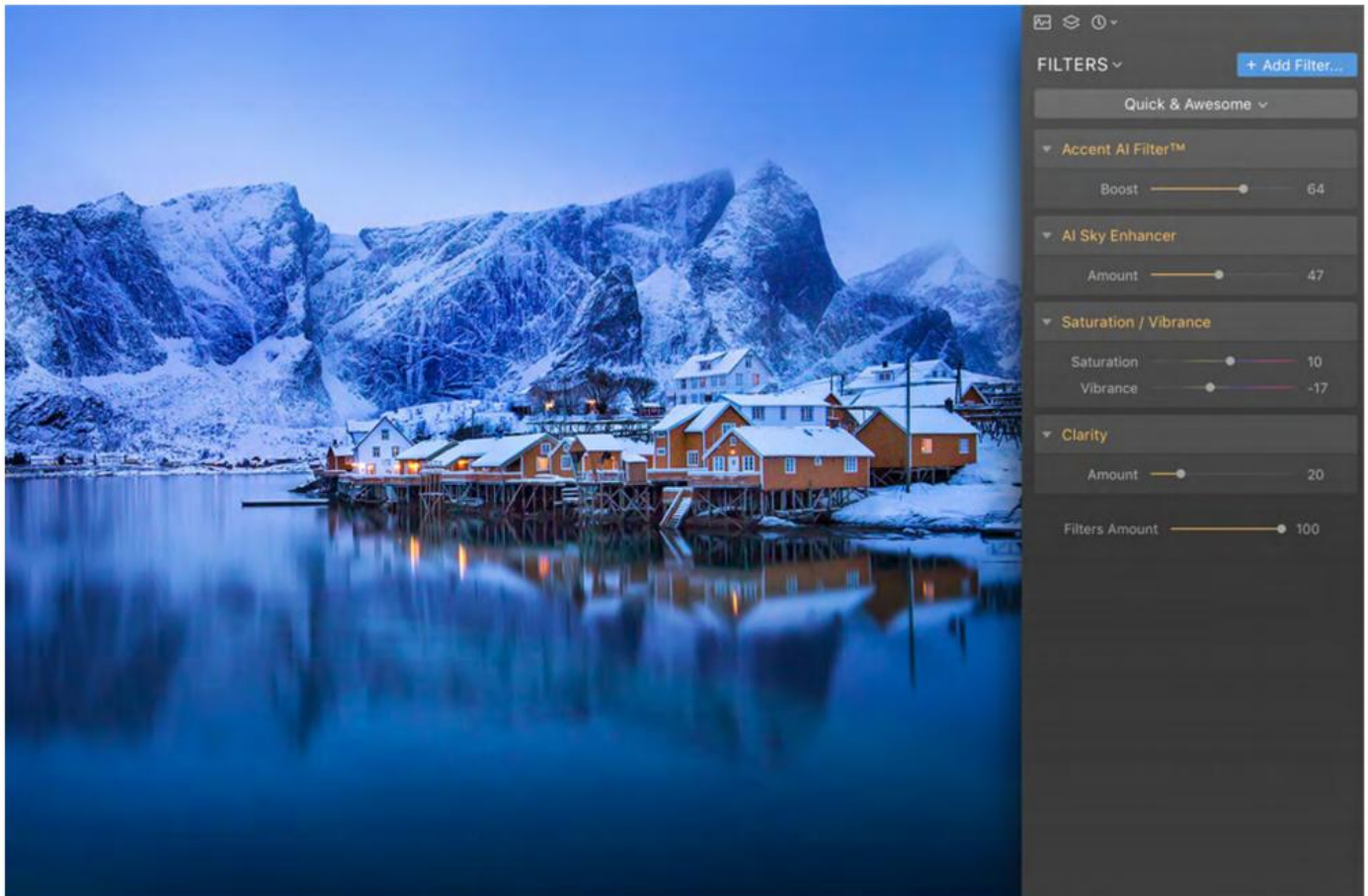
2. GIMP - <https://www.gimp.org>

GIMP is a cross-platform image editor available for GNU/Linux, OS X, Windows and more operating systems. Best of all, it is free. It comes with layers, masks, advanced filters, colour adjustment tools and transformations. It also includes a large array of step-by-step tutorials and troubleshooting guides to get you started.



3. Luminar - <https://skylum.com/luminar-2>

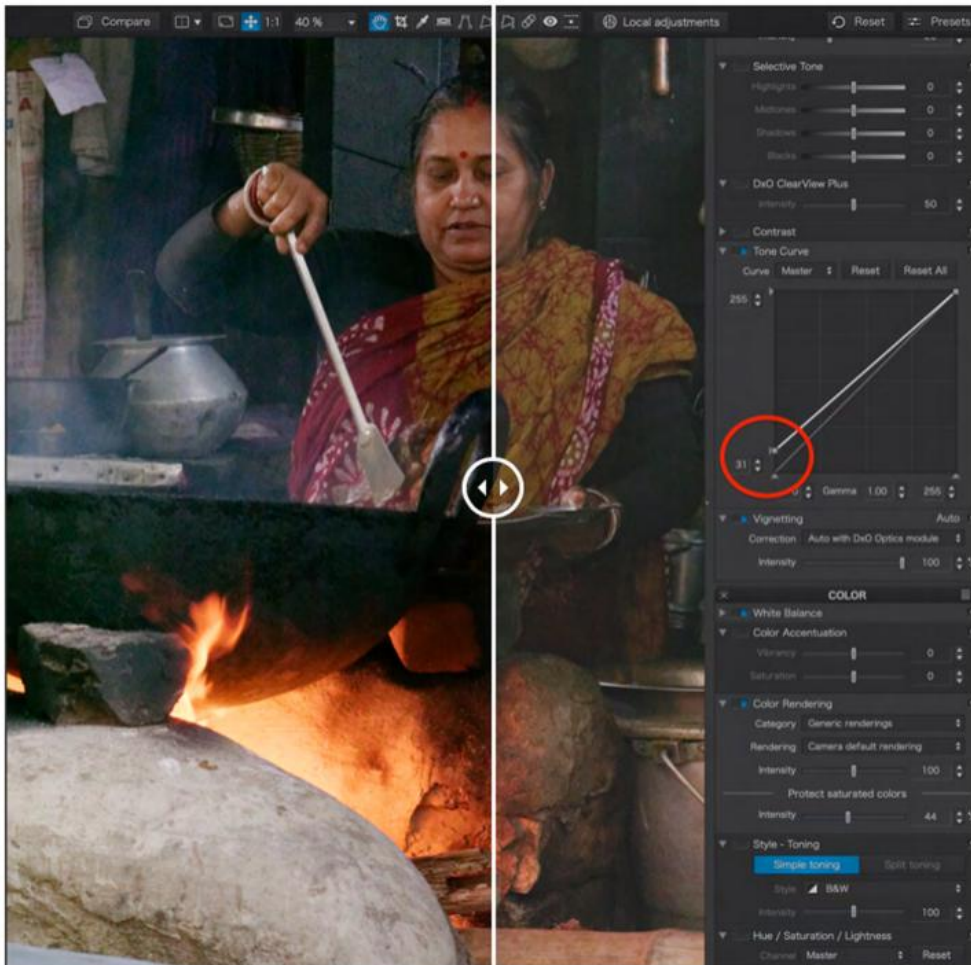
Luminar is a full featured photo editor and organizer. Luminar presents you with a wall of photos so you can view whole portions of your library at a glance, complete with adjustable thumbnail views. It is non-destructive, with each edit recorded in the catalog. You can go back into the history panel to revert to a previous edit or to the original photo. Think of it as being similar to Lightroom but for a once off fee (currently \$100 USD). I recommend downloading a trial version to see if it suits your needs.



4. DxO PhotoLab - <https://www.dxo.com/dxo-photolab/>

DxO PhotoLab is a powerful, high-end program that delivers superb images from raw files, even from very average cameras and lenses. Its local adjustment tools are extremely effective and its Denoise tool is incredible. This is the same company that owns Nik Photoshop & LR Plugins and uses the same technology in this editing software.

I feel it's PhotoLibrary organising tool isn't as good as Lighroom, but for a once off fee of \$100 USD it's a great choice for those that simply want to edit files and not necessarily organise them.



5. Pixelmator Photo - <https://www.pixelmator.com/photo/>

2019 Apple design winner, Pixelmator Photo is one of the best ways to edit your images on an iPad. It manages to deliver impressive editing power in a beautiful, uncluttered interface. For beginners, Pixelmator is surprisingly approachable (your edits are conveniently nondestructive). For experts who wish to maximize every last pixel of their iPad screen, it offers a robust toolset and support for RAW images. Best of all, it's only \$5 USD.





Student image by Daphne Stevens, CA
ISO 1000, f/4, 1/50 second



Student image by Ed Stines, CA
ISO 100, f/5.6, 1/1250 second



Student image by Barbara Reams, US
ISO 125, f/6.3, 1/250 seconds



Student image by Yvonne Warriner
ISO 200, f/6.3, 1/100 seconds

Shoot 25% More Than You Think

By Eric Kim

If you see an amazing character once in your life, realise that you may never see them again. So live life without regrets and make the photograph.

For this photo, I saw this amazing woman in the streets of NYC and said to her, "Oh my God miss, you are the most incredible looking woman I have seen all day. Do you mind if I made a few photographs of you?" She was quite humbled and said, "Of course!"

I got very close with her with my camera, and took many photographs, shooting some with flash, some without. I asked her to look up, and to look down at me.

On the 19th frame, she started bursting out laughing and said, "You're taking so many photos, you're crazy!" and started laughing. On that frame, I captured the "decisive moment."

After capturing the moment, I still wasn't 100% sure whether I got an interesting photograph or not, so I kept clicking, around 10 more frames. As a general rule-of-thumb, when I think I've got the photograph, I try to take 25% more photographs (because you never know if you might catch an even more interesting photograph after-the-fact).



Shoot From The Gut

“My photography is not ‘brain photography’. I put my brain under the pillow when I shoot. I shoot with my heart and with my stomach.” - Anders Petersen

Anders Petersen is one of the most influential contemporary master photographers. He shoots with a simple point-and-shoot film camera (Contax T3) and shoots soulful black and white images which he refers to as “personal documentary.” He makes himself and the people he meets as his main subjects, and he shoots from the heart.

A photograph without emotion is dead. The problem that a lot of photographers make is that they try to become too analytical with their photography. They are too preoccupied with composition, framing, form, nice light, and they forget the most important thing of making a memorable image: creating an image that has heart, soul, and passion.

When you're out shooting, try not to be too analytical. Shoot from your intuition and your guts. If you find anything even remotely interesting, don't selfcensor yourself.

Don't let your brain tell you: “Don't take that shot, it is boring, and nobody will find it interesting.” Take the photograph anyway, because you can always delete it later on if you decide at the computer you don't like it.



Print Your Photos

*"A photograph doesn't exist until it is printed." -
Constantine Manos*

In today's digital age, we are so used to seeing our images on a screen. We see them on our laptops, tablets, and smartphones. But the print is a dying medium. When is the last time you printed 4x6 prints of a holiday trip, instead of just sharing and tagging them on Facebook?

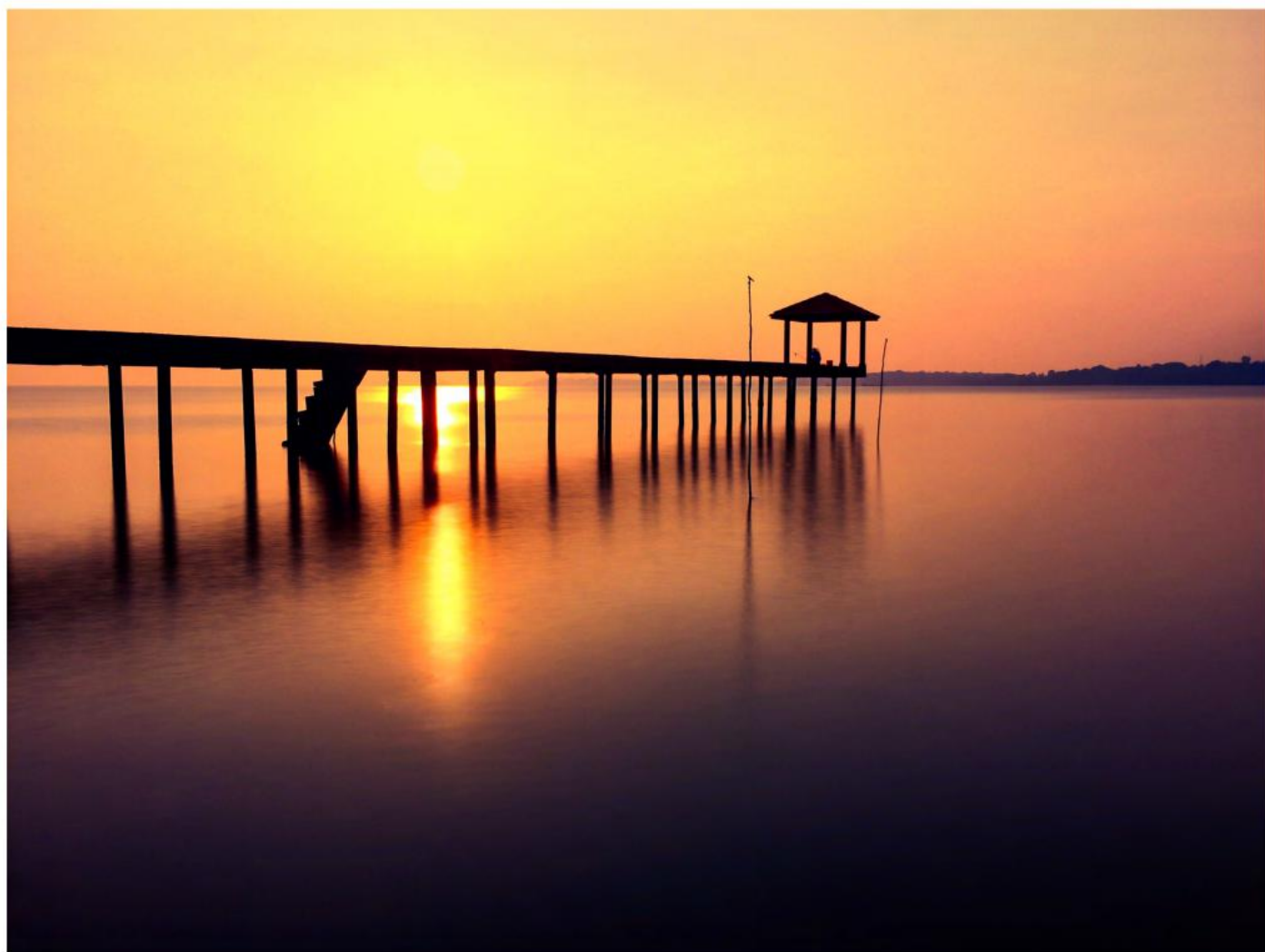
Constantine Manos says a photograph doesn't exist until it is printed. If a photograph isn't printed, it only exists metaphorically in pixels. Printing a photograph makes it physical and brings it into the "real world." A printed photograph has texture, weight, and takes up physical space.

In a manifesto called "The Print," Constantine Manos shares the importance of printing our images:

*"There are still photographers who believe that a photograph does not exist until it is a print. There remains in their memory the experience of working in a darkroom and recalling the magic of seeing an image gradually appear on a piece of paper in a tray of liquid. If processed and stored properly this print can last for generations. It becomes a treasure. It can be framed and hung in a favorite spot, to become an object of daily pleasure and comfort. It is a real object we can hold in our hands, not a negative or an image floating around in space and stored in cold machines. Let us celebrate the print." -
Constantine Manos*

Prints are cheap. You can get them done at home, at the local discount store, or the local photography lab. You can also get them done affordably online. Print out your photos as small 4x6's, give them away to friends as gifts, hang them on your walls, and enjoy the physicality of the print as an object. Lay them out on a table to edit your photography projects and sequence them.

Prints also make for fantastic presents to close friends and family. The joy I get from giving away my prints is quite possibly the most joy I have ever received in photography.



Marketing Tips For Photographers

As business owners, we are always looking for ways to get our names out there and be noticed. Especially in such a competitive field as photography. It seems as though there is a photographer on every corner and the industry keeps growing daily.

So how can we, as photographers, really get our name on the map and stay relevant to the areas we serve? And more importantly, what are some ways we can do it for cheap or completely free?

Here are a few things that you can do to make a name for yourself and draw interest to your services.



Social Media Marketing

One of the most commonly used sources of cheap or free marketing is social media. Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, etc.. are all wonderful platforms to take advantage of when looking to build up your clientele.

While you do have the option to pay small fees to boost your presence on these platforms, you also have the benefit of all of the free perks these sites have to offer.

It seems everyone has a social media account of some sort. This day and age, it has become very common for this to be the main way people stay in touch with not only family and friends, but also businesses for services needed.

Having a business profile for your photography business on social media platforms can greatly benefit your business and social presence.

Use sites like Facebook and Instagram to post special offers, announce news and events, and share your work and images with your followers. You can also share any blog posts that will take them to your website.



Blogging

Speaking of blogging, that alone is another easy and affordable way to market yourself.

If you service clients and do photo sessions only, you can blog about sessions where you can show “sneak peeks” and maybe tell a behind the scenes story.

This will help potential clients get a more personal feel of what a session would be like with you. And as an added bonus, clients are likely to share your blog posts that puts them in the spotlight with family and friends. If you are more of a photography educator, and your services are geared more towards other photographers, you can use blogging in a completely different way. For example, you could share posts/articles covering everything from shooting and editing techniques, business and marketing tips, and news on the latest gear.

The possibilities are really endless with blogging. The key is to stay consistent and interesting. And always add links to your website and social media platforms in your posts. This will ensure you get noticed on all of your self-marketing sites.



Work With Vendors

Many vendors are always looking for photographers to work with. Whether it be a wedding venue, or something as simple as a florist, vendors use professional photographers to get nice images showcasing their services.

When a vendor uses you, typically they will give credit to the photographer when using their images for any type of advertisement. This is a win-win for you, because not only are you getting paid for your photography services, you also gain free advertisements from the vendor themselves.

Work For Free?

This is a controversial subject for many business owners, because obviously everyone wants to get paid for their work and services.

However, doing a little free work here and there could really work to your advantage in the long run. A few hours of your time could turn into multiple new clients and more business for you.

Benefits, parades, festivals, etc. are just a few examples of events you could offer your services for free. Not only will this get you noticed, but it will show you care about your community and enjoy using your services for good causes.

Giveaways

People like free stuff. Period. Consider hosting a contest or giveaway of some sort occasionally.

Whether you are giving away a free session for new clients, an album of prints for previous clients, or even a camera or some type of gear (if you cater to other photographers), having others share your name and participate in contests is a wonderful way to gain exposure.

Exposure is crucial for photographers. Both in the beginning when you are first launching your business, and when you have become established but want to stay relevant.

With so many new photographers popping up every day, the competition is strong and the last thing you want to do is be forgot about.



Business Cards and Flyers

This is a method that has been used for many years, before social media was even a thing. However, you have to remember that sometimes going back to the basics is necessary.

The older generation isn't as tech savvy as the younger generation. But, they are still in just as need of business services as the younger generation. Putting out business cards and flyers to local businesses, schools, etc. is a great way to get the attention of that specific target audience.

In Summary:

Whether you are a “newbie” just trying to get noticed or a rookie that has already made a name for yourself, the goal is to use every marketing outlet possible to stay relevant and continuously build your clientele.

Free or cheap marketing means more money in your pocket. So take advantage of the plethora of ways you can market yourself and watch your business take off!



Word Of Mouth Advertising

Word of mouth is crucial for business owners, including photographers. When you have the general public giving nice reviews and recommendation for your services, you are basically having a community of people doing free advertising for you.

Leave Clients Happy

The most important thing to take into consideration is the service that you provide. The better and more pleasurable the experience is for clients, the more likely they are to say good things about you. When a client has never used a specific service/business before, it is always helpful to have as many people as you can speaking highly of you.

Any photographer can promise a wonderful experience, but promises and advertisements are just that, words. You need people backing you up and supporting you who can speak of the service they received from you personally. It makes you more credible and shows that you have had happy satisfied customers.

Just make sure that you give each client the same level of time, care, and professionalism. A couple of bad experiences could give you a bad reputation really quickly. Stay consistent and treat each and every client equally.

Give Them An Incentive

Sometimes all your clients need is a little bit of incentive to help you get your name out there. There are several ways you can do this.

For example, consider giving them a discount for future sessions for every new client you get referred by them.

Not only will you gain new clients, but chances are you will have just gained a returning client who will appreciate the discount. It's like killing two birds with one stone, and the discounted price will be well worth it for your business in the long run.



Sharing on Social Media

We live in a digital age where a majority of the population uses social media platforms to showcase their photos.

Whether it's their engagement/wedding photos, family photos, or photos of their precious little newest addition to the family, people just want to show off the things that make them happiest!

Photographers typically share sneak peeks from their sessions on their own social media platforms. But what about the digital images the client receives?

If you provide digital images with your sessions, you may want to have it in your contract that your name is attached to any images that are shared via social media.

This may seem a little selfish and many photographers are intimidated by requesting this of clients, however, there is nothing selfish about this at all.

The exact set of "rules" you set between your client and yourself is totally up to you. But there needs to be a way you receive credit for your work.

You can give them a set of watermarked images for social media sharing only, which will obviously showcase your name. Or, you could even have them link your business profile along with the images when shared. Using both methods works even better!

To Sum It All Up

Word of mouth marketing could hands down be one of the greatest things for your business. Marketing in itself can be very time consuming and sometimes very costly.

Having a group of people (the bigger the better) reassuring others that your services are worth every penny really goes a long way in the industry.

If you make sure the services you are offering are consistent and pleasurable with each and every client, and you are leaving them completely satisfied and happy with the results, word of mouth marketing will come naturally.

However, if you want to use incentives to have them more encouraged to spread your name in a good way, that is perfectly fine also. Just make sure you are providing the skills and services and professionalism that you are advertising.

Also, always remember that it's a two way street. A couple of bad experiences can lead to word of mouth marketing too, just not in a good way. Get people saying good things, make them want to give you good reviews and recommend you to others!

The more great things others are saying about you, the more excited others will be to share the same experience and use your services. The goal should be to have the whole town knowing your name and seeing your work.

And last but not least, word of mouth doesn't have to cost you a dime, nor your time, as you will have others doing the work for you.

This month's challenge is: Home Life

This month's challenge is 'Home Life'. Upload your shots to our private facebook group (DSLR Photography Course students only) and label them '#homelife'. Don't forget to add your camera settings and a little about how you took the image.



*Highlights from last month's challenge ~
Light*

Photo by Nola Gray

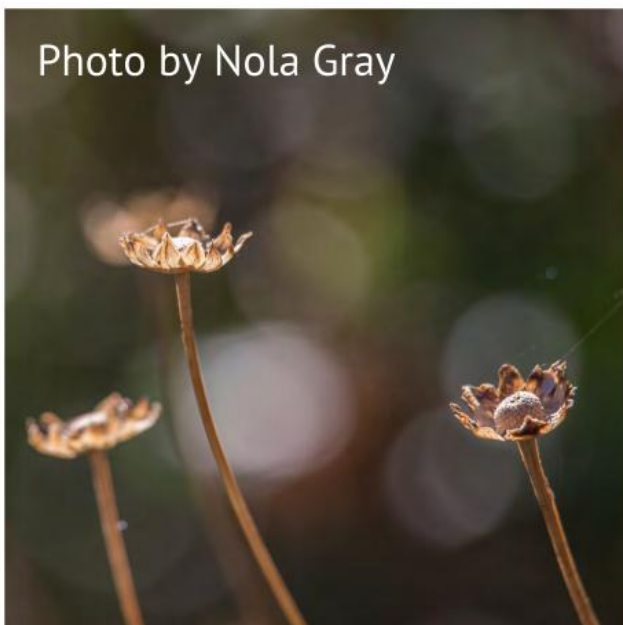


Photo by
Bobbie Avery

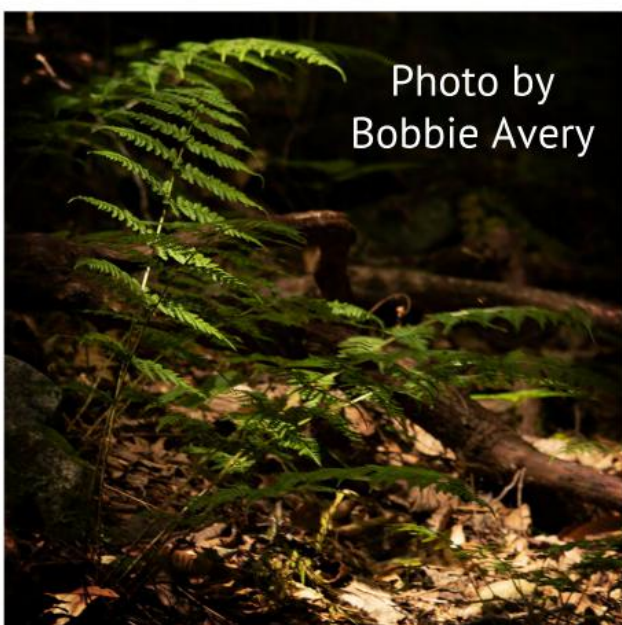
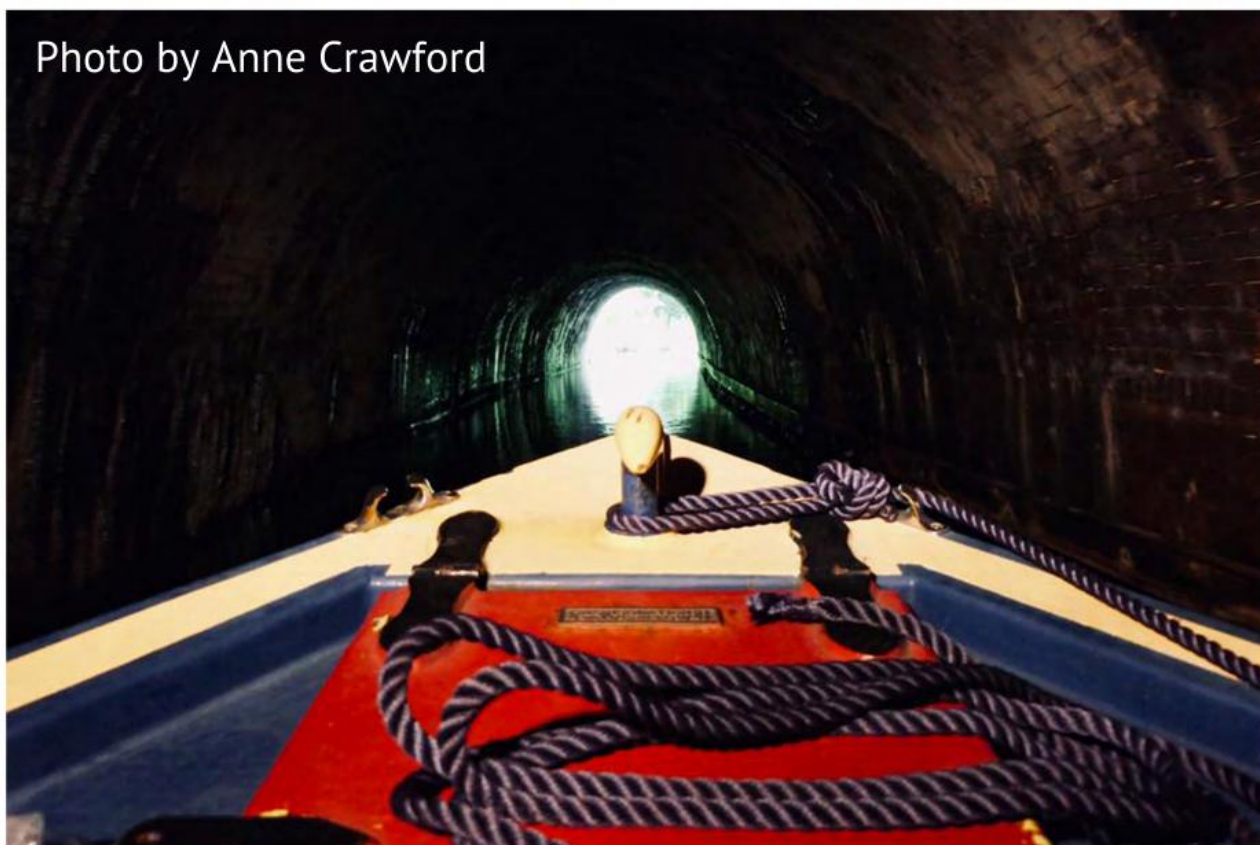


Photo by Anne Crawford





Student image by Cheryl Humphrey, US
ISO 100, f/6.3, 1/2000 second



Student image by Roz Harman, AU
ISO 100, f/5.6, 10 seconds

Embrace Failure



"Luck, or perhaps serendipity, plays a big role. But you never know what is going to happen. And what is most exciting is when the utterly unexpected happens, and you manage to be there at the right place at the right time - and push the shutter at the right moment. Most of the time it doesn't work out that way. Street photography is 99.9% about failure." - Alex Webb

Street photography is all about failure. As Alex Webb said, "Street photography is 99.9% about failure." Every time you click the shutter, there is only a 1% chance that you will make an interesting shot. The majority of the time, you might shoot an entire day, not get a single good shot, and feel disappointed and frustrated.

Know that failure is a good thing. The more you fail, the more likely you are to succeed. As Thomas Edison once said: "If you want to increase your success rate, double your failure rate."

You can control the effort, not the results. Meaning, you can control putting in 8 hours of shooting in one day, and how hard you work. What you can't control is whether you get a good shot or not.

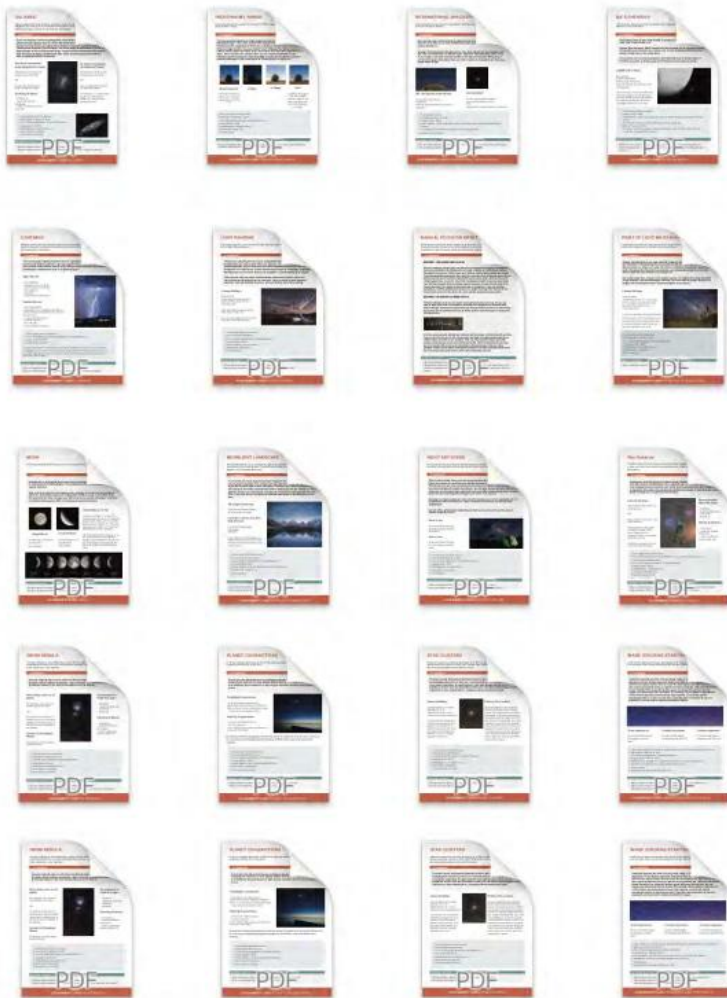
In my street photography, I often found that the more I go out and bring my camera, the more "lucky" I get. When I have my camera with me, the more opportunities I see. Luck isn't some magical thing that hits us like lightning. However luck favors the prepared.

Be prepared by always having your camera with you, always observing your scenes and environment, and know that every once in a while, you will be at the "right place at the right time." If you're comfortable with your camera and skilled enough, you will also click the shutter at the right moment.

When you fail to get the shot, don't become discouraged. Rather, learn from your failures and mistakes. What caused you to miss the shot? Was it because your camera wasn't setup properly? Was it because your camera was in your bag (and not in your hand)? Was it because you were too nervous and didn't have the courage to click the shutter? Learn from your failures, and the closer you will become to mastering your photography.

ASSIGNMENT SHEETS COMING SOON

OVER 100 Sheets that will give you over 200 photography assignments,
covering everything you can imagine!



LIGHT PAINTING

This sheet will teach you how to blend light painting techniques along with a Milky Way landscape.



© SLR Photography Guide

ASSIGNMENT

The purpose of light painting is to give recognizable detail to the landscape foreground so you only need to make one exposure. One shot makes post processing easier, as you don't have to combine separate exposures for the sky and foreground. Your light source can be something as simple as a flashlight, headlamp, flashlight app on your mobile phone, car headlights. i.e anything that gives off light.

First step is to take test shots of the landscape with ambient light to make sure you've exposed correctly for the sky and stars. Once you have a good night time exposure, start light painting the scene, but don't change the camera settings.

Camera Settings

Manual Mode
Shutter Speed 20-30 seconds
Aperture: Wide open f/2.8-f/4
ISO 1600-3200

Take a test shot to expose for the Milky Way or Stars first.

Once you are happy with the results, then bring in the light painting.



1. Use a tripod and remote release
2. Set camera to Manual Mode
3. Turn off Image Stabilisation / Vibration Reduction
4. Image Quality - RAW
5. White Balance - Daylight / Sunny
6. Drive Mode - Single Shot
7. Focus Manual

HOW DID YOU GO?

- Did you have fun experimenting with different light positions?
- Were you able to capture the night sky and light painting on the foreground?

ASSIGNMENT CARD: LIGHT PAINTING

<https://www.slrphotographyguide.com/photography-courses/>